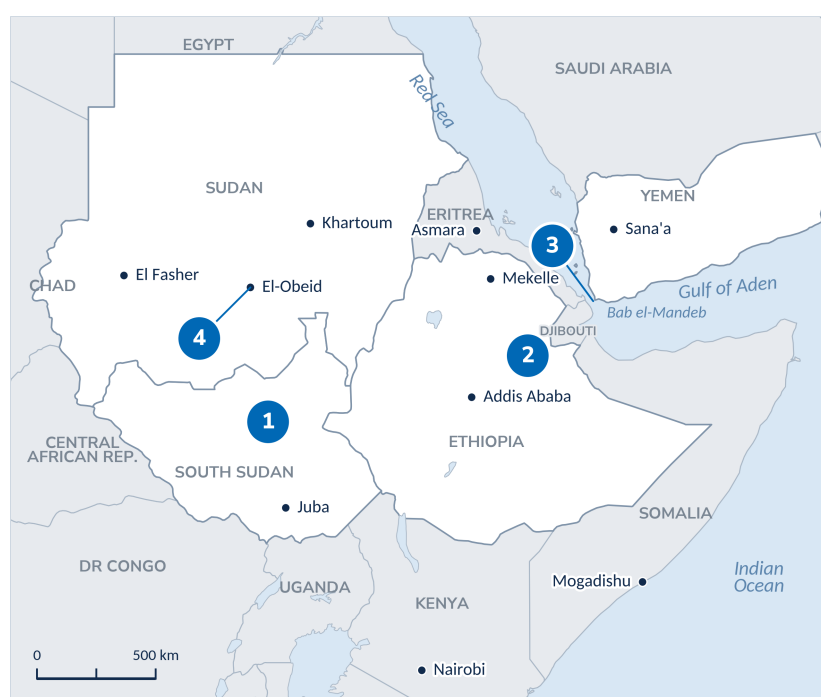


Nala Weekly

A weekly product of the Nala Center

This week's Nala Weekly tracks four fast-moving flashpoints reshaping the security environment in the Horn of Africa and the Red Sea region: South Sudan's collapsing election timeline, the relapse of Ethiopia into civil war, the escalating Houthi chokehold on Red Sea shipping, and the Sudan war's shift towards Kordofan following the fall of El Fasher.



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Flashpoints covered in this issue. Map: Nala Center, using Natural Earth boundary data. Boundaries and names shown do not imply endorsement or acceptance by the Nala Center.

1

South Sudan

Key dates

March 2025

Riek Machar placed under house arrest

21–22 September 2026

Election law amended and transitional government dissolved

22 December 2026

General elections, the first since independence

Elections on the Brink

South Sudan is finally headed for general elections on 22 December 2026, the country's first vote since independence in 2011, after repeated postponements. On 22 September 2026, President Salva Kiir dissolved the transitional government, hours after signing amendments to the National Elections Act that removed the requirement to complete a permanent constitution and a national census before the poll. While this bypasses a procedural hurdle, it does not resolve the underlying credibility and legitimacy deficits, which risk turning the elections into a major flashpoint, the most serious the country has faced since the 2013–2018 civil war.

The main opposition, the Sudan People's Liberation Movement-in-Opposition (SPLM-IO), has rejected the amendments that cleared the path to elections, while its leader, former First Vice-President Riek Machar, remains under house arrest and on trial on charges including treason and murder, which he denies. Other signatories to the 2018 peace agreement, including a breakaway SPLM-IO faction, have aligned with President Kiir in backing the December poll. With less than three months to the elections, the feasibility of South Sudan holding a democratic election is significantly constrained by gaps in voter registration, civic education and election security, in the wake of violent clashes which continue to erupt in different parts of the country.

Given the credibility and legitimacy questions around the elections, South Sudan's election trajectory is likely to take the following paths:

- A** Polls proceed on a truncated timetable amid low credibility, leading to contested results and localised violence rather than nationwide collapse.
- B** Some opposition groups accept participation in the election, producing a flawed but broadly accepted vote.
- C** Opposition groups led by Riek Machar's SPLM-IO boycott the elections, and Machar's continued detention triggers a return to armed confrontation before or immediately after polling, forcing a return to power-sharing.

Recommendation

To pull Juba back from the brink, South Sudan's international partners (the United States, Britain and Norway, among others), as well as regional bodies, especially the Intergovernmental Authority on Development (IGAD) and the African Union (AU), should deploy robust preventive diplomacy mechanisms to broker Riek Machar's release and guarantees for opposition groups to participate in the forthcoming elections.

2

Ethiopia

Key dates

November 2022

Pretoria agreement ends the 2020–2022 Tigray war

17 September 2026

US Ethiopia-related sanctions emergency expires

20 September 2026

Seven groups form the Alliance for Survival

23 September 2026

Alliance offensive begins in Tigray, Afar and Amhara

A New TPLF Rebellion

On 20 September 2026, seven armed and political movements announced the formation of the Ethiopian Peoples' Forces Alliance for Survival (EPFAS), widely known as the Alliance for Survival, seeking to overthrow Prime Minister Abiy Ahmed and install a transitional government. EPFAS brings together the Tigray People's Liberation Front (TPLF), its main military force; the Amhara Fano National Movement, whose chairman Zemene Kassie read the founding declaration; the Oromo Liberation Army; a faction of the Ogaden National Liberation Front; an Afar group; the Benishangul People's Liberation Movement; and the Gumuz People's Democratic Movement. The offensive the alliance launched on 23 September, and the armed confrontations with the Ethiopian National Defense Force (ENDF) that followed, effectively end the November 2022 Pretoria agreement, which had ended the 2020–2022 conflict in the Tigray region.

The conflict risks regional instability. Ethiopia's military chief, Field Marshal Birhanu Julia, has accused Eritrea, Sudan and Egypt of backing the alliance, without presenting public evidence; Sudan's army has rejected the claim as baseless and Eritrea has accused Addis Ababa of shifting blame, while Egypt had not publicly responded at the time of writing. Separately, the US national emergency declared in September 2021 over the crisis in Ethiopia (Executive Order 14046) expired on 17 September 2026, lifting sanctions on Eritrea's military and its ruling party, the People's Front for Democracy and Justice. A history of mutual destabilisation in the Horn of Africa casts a long shadow over Ethiopia's renewed civil war, with dire humanitarian and cross-border security risks that threaten the entire region's stability. Ethiopia is Africa's second most populous country after Nigeria, with over 130 million people, now at risk of displacement and violence.

The civil war is likely to take the following trajectory:

- A** A protracted multi-front war of attrition with no decisive military outcome in the near term; the capital, Addis Ababa, will face armed insurgency from the Benishangul-Gumuz, Oromia, Amhara, Afar, Somali and Tigray regions.
- B** The ENDF leverages its air power advantage and advances significantly against EPFAS, especially in the north, prompting direct Eritrean intervention and effectively regionalising the conflict across the Horn.
- C** The rebel alliance expands territorial control and lays siege to Addis Ababa and the federal government, holding out for a power bargain or as a prelude to ousting Prime Minister Abiy Ahmed.

Recommendation

Regional peace and security bodies, the AU and IGAD, should mediate a ceasefire to re-establish a modified and expanded Pretoria framework before EPFAS consolidates its territorial gains.

3

Red Sea / Bab el-Mandeb

Key dates

20 July 2026

Houthis declare a blockade of Saudi ports and shipping

24 August 2026

Houthis claim a strike on a vessel off Yanbu

11 September 2026

Houthis seize Mayun (Perim) Island

Houthis Advance in the Red Sea

On 20 July 2026, the Yemeni Houthi militant group declared a blockade of Saudi Arabian ports and shipping, and on 11 September it seized Mayun Island, also known as Perim, at the southern entrance of the Red Sea, completing its takeover of the Bab el-Mandeb area. The group has claimed escalating strikes on Saudi oil facilities, including at Jizan and Yanbu, and on tankers in the Red Sea, in a calculated move to establish a chokehold on the Red Sea and the global economy as pressure points to force the United States to halt hostilities and the naval blockade against Iran.

The Houthi attacks threaten navigation in the Red Sea and the Gulf of Aden. Before the attacks that began in late 2023 forced widespread rerouting, the Suez-Red Sea route carried around 11 per cent of global seaborne trade by volume and about 12 per cent of seaborne-traded oil, making this a major risk to the global economy and to the regional economies on both sides of the Red Sea.

The seizure of Mayun Island has effectively opened a Red Sea front in the US-Israel war with Iran. Should the Houthis escalate attacks on tankers and tighten their chokehold, the following scenarios are likely over a period of weeks to months:

- A** Intermittent and targeted strikes on Saudi- and Israel-linked shipping continue and escalate to other international vessels, hiking shipping insurance premiums and causing significant shipping delays due to re-routing, without a full blockade.
- B** Houthi attacks widen into a sustained blockade of Saudi exports, drawing renewed US-led coalition strikes and thereby regionalising the Red Sea crisis.

The Red Sea corridor

Mayun Island, seized by the Houthis on 11 September 2026, sits at the southern entrance of the Red Sea. The Houthis have claimed strikes on Saudi oil facilities at Yanbu and on a vessel off the port.

○ Locations named in this section

- - - Indicative shipping route

Map: Nala Center, using Natural Earth boundary data.



4

Sudan

Key dates

26 October 2025

El Fasher falls to the RSF after an 18-month siege

June 2026

RSF tightens its siege of El-Obeid

Late July 2026

SAF reopens the Khartoum–El-Obeid corridor

War Shifts to Kordofan

The centre of gravity of Sudan's civil war has moved to North Kordofan, where the Rapid Support Forces (RSF) have kept El-Obeid, a city of about half a million people, under siege-like conditions using the same starvation-and-drone tactics that preceded the fall of El Fasher in October 2025. Although the Sudan Armed Forces (SAF) reopened the Khartoum–El-Obeid corridor in late July 2026, RSF drone strikes on the city have continued, raising fears of a second mass-atrocity event and reinforcing a de facto, Libya-style territorial partition between an RSF-controlled west and an SAF-controlled riverine and eastern state.

The conflict reached a critical phase in October 2025, as de facto territorial partitioning began to emerge, with the warring parties shifting from pursuing military victory to consolidating their territorial gains. The fall of El Fasher to the RSF on 26 October 2025 left the whole of Darfur under RSF control, while the SAF holds Khartoum, the north and the east, and Kordofan remains contested. The UN documented more than 6,000 killings in El Fasher in the first three days alone, researchers have put the death toll at 60,000 or more, and a UN fact-finding mission later found that the atrocities, including mass killings and widespread rape, met the core criteria of genocide.

Since mid-2026, residents of El-Obeid have reported food prices rising by up to 300 per cent and water prices doubling, as drone strikes have hit the city's power, water and fuel infrastructure and humanitarian access has narrowed.

In the coming weeks or months, the conflict is likely to take the following trajectory:

- A** The RSF consolidates its Kordofan gains while the SAF holds Khartoum and the east, entrenching a de facto partition without a formal settlement.
- B** Expanded international arms-embargo enforcement and AU/UN mediation produce a negotiated ceasefire ahead of an El-Obeid mass-casualty event.
- C** El-Obeid falls under conditions mirroring El Fasher, triggering a second atrocity crisis and accelerating de jure territorial fragmentation.

About the Nala Center

The Nala Center is a youth-led, nonpartisan policy and research think tank based in Nairobi, Kenya. More about its work is available at www.nalacenter.org.

About Nala Weekly

Nala Weekly is a weekly product of the Nala Center. Each issue offers concise analysis of key developments, the trajectories they are likely to take and, where relevant, recommendations for policymakers. The analysis in this issue reflects information available as at 29 September 2026. Scenarios describe plausible trajectories and are not predictions.

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